
ORBITS

NOTES ON CALCULATIONS ON CLASSICAL ORBITS UNDER GRAVITY

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Chapter 1

Central forces

1.1 Introduction

A central force is a force that acts only in the radial direction. In other words the force only depends on the distance from the centre. As such a central force can be defined like so

$$\mathbf{F} = f(r)\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (1.1.1)$$

The equation of motion for a central force is then

$$\ddot{\mathbf{r}} = \dot{\mathbf{v}} = \frac{\mathbf{F}}{m} = \frac{f(r)}{m}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (1.1.2)$$

where we have used $\mathbf{v} = \dot{\mathbf{r}}$.

1.2 Angular Momentum

One important parameter for a central force is the angular momentum. The angular momentum is defined as the cross product of the position vector $\mathbf{r}$ and the momentum vector $\mathbf{p} = m\mathbf{v}$

$$\mathbf{L} = \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{p} = m\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v} \quad (1.2.1)$$

The mass m is fixed so it is more convenient to use the specific angular momentum

$$\mathbf{h} = \frac{\mathbf{L}}{m} = \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v} \quad (1.2.2)$$

1.2.1 Conservation of Angular Momentum

We can show that angular momentum is a constant of the motion by showing it's rate of change with respect to time is zero, ie it is fixed and unchanging. We start then by taking the derivative with respect to time.

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{\mathbf{h}} &= \frac{d}{dt}(\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}) \\ &= \dot{\mathbf{r}} \times \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{r} \times \dot{\mathbf{v}} \\ &= \mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{v} + \mathbf{r} \times \dot{\mathbf{v}} \\ &= \mathbf{r} \times \dot{\mathbf{v}} \end{aligned} \quad (1.2.3)$$

We have used the fact that the vector product of any vector with itself is zero. We can now substitute in equation 1.1.2¹ for $\dot{\mathbf{v}}$

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{\mathbf{h}} &= \mathbf{r} \times \dot{\mathbf{v}} \\ &= \mathbf{r} \times \frac{f(r)}{m} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\ &= \frac{f(r)}{mr} \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{r} \\ &= \mathbf{0} \end{aligned} \quad (1.2.4)$$

This shows that the angular momentum is a constant of the motion for a central force.

1.3 Potential Energy

The potential energy of a particle at a point is the amount of work that an external agent must do against the force exerted by

¹page 1

the system on that particle from a chose reference point where we define the potential energy to be zero to that point.

In the case of a central force it is typical to choose the reference point to be at a radius of ∞ for attractive forces and to be at a radius of zero for repulsive forces. Additionally note that it is the work done against the force applied to the particle by the system, so the force the external agent must apply is equal and opposite the force applied by the system. This means when calculating the work done by the external agent, the force must be the negative of the force applied by the system.

Here we want the potential energy at a radius r , so we integrate from ∞ to r

$$\begin{aligned} V(r) &= \int_{\infty}^r -\mathbf{F}(r') \cdot d\mathbf{r}' \\ &= - \int_{\infty}^r f(r') \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot dr' \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\ &= - \int_{\infty}^r f(r') dr' \end{aligned} \tag{1.3.1}$$

If we take the derivative of both sides with respect to r we get

$$\frac{dV}{dr} = -f(r) \tag{1.3.2}$$

1.4 Kinetic Energy

The kinetic energy of a particle is given by

$$T(v) = \frac{1}{2} m \mathbf{v} \cdot \mathbf{v} = \frac{1}{2} m v^2 \tag{1.4.1}$$

1.5 Total Energy

The total energy is the sum of kinetic energy and potential energy

$$E = \frac{1}{2} m v^2 + V(r) \tag{1.5.1}$$

Again it is often easier to use the specific total energy ϵ

$$\epsilon = \frac{E}{m} = \frac{1}{2}v^2 + \frac{V(r)}{m} \quad (1.5.2)$$

to make this a little easier still we will let $\tilde{V} = \frac{V(r)}{m}$, so we get

$$\epsilon = \frac{E}{m} = \frac{1}{2}v^2 + \tilde{V} \quad (1.5.3)$$

1.5.1 Conservation of Total Energy

As before with the angular momentum, we can show that the total energy is a constant of motion by taking the derivative with respect to time

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d\epsilon}{dt} &= \frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{1}{2}v^2 + \tilde{V} \right) \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \frac{dv^2}{dt} + \frac{d\tilde{V}}{dt} \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \frac{dv^2}{dv} \frac{dv}{dt} + \frac{d\tilde{V}}{dr} \frac{dr}{dt} \\ &= \frac{1}{2} 2v \frac{dv}{dt} - \frac{f(r)}{m} v \\ &= v \left(\dot{v} - \frac{f(r)}{m} \right) \end{aligned} \quad (1.5.4)$$

From equation 1.1.2²

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{v} &= \sqrt{\dot{\mathbf{v}} \cdot \dot{\mathbf{v}}} \\ &= \sqrt{\frac{f(r)}{m} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \frac{f(r)}{m} \hat{\mathbf{r}}} \\ &= \frac{f(r)}{m} \sqrt{\hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}}} \\ &= \frac{f(r)}{m} \end{aligned} \quad (1.5.5)$$

²page 1

we can then substitute equation 1.5.5³ into equation 1.5.4⁴ giving

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{d\epsilon}{dt} &= v \left(\dot{v} - \frac{f(r)}{m} \right) \\
 &= v \left(\frac{f(r)}{m} - \frac{f(r)}{m} \right) \\
 &= 0
 \end{aligned} \tag{1.5.6}$$

This then shows that total energy is a constant of the motion for a central force

1.6 Summary

In this chapter we have shown that both the angular momentum and the total energy is conserved under a central force.

³page 4

⁴page 4

Chapter 2

Gravity

2.1 Introduction

Now that we have looked at central forces more generally, we can apply what we have found to gravitational attraction between two bodies.

The force between two particles a distance r apart with the central larger mass M and the smaller mass m is given by

$$\mathbf{F} = -\frac{GMm}{r^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (2.1.1)$$

We will introduce the standard gravitational parameter $\mu = GM$ here to simplify the equations, we will also use the specific force, ie the force per unit mass, also known as the acceleration for a body with fixed mass.

$$\frac{\mathbf{F}}{m} = -\frac{\mu}{r^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (2.1.2)$$

2.2 Gravitational Potential Energy

As seen earlier, the potential energy is given by equation 1.3.1¹

¹page 3

$$\begin{aligned}
V(r) &= - \int_{\infty}^r -\frac{\mu m}{r'^2} dr' \\
\frac{V(r)}{m} &= \mu \int_{\infty}^r \frac{1}{r'^2} dr' \\
&= -\mu \left[\frac{1}{r} - \frac{1}{\infty} \right] \\
&= -\frac{\mu}{r}
\end{aligned} \tag{2.2.1}$$

2.3 Total Energy

The specific total energy is then given by

$$\epsilon = \frac{v^2}{2} - \frac{\mu}{r} \tag{2.3.1}$$

2.4 The Eccentricity Vector

For inverse square central forces there is another constant of motion. This is known as the eccentricity vector. The reason it is called this will become clear later, but for this section we will work through it's derivation. There are a lot of moving parts with this derivation so we will start with some smaller seemingly independant calculations that will ultimately get us to the eccentricity vector and the fact it is a constant of the motion.

2.4.1 Rate of change of velocity

The rate of change of velocity is given by equation 2.1.2², since the rate of change of velocity is the acceleration, which is just the specific force, ie $\frac{\mathbf{F}}{m}$, so

²page 7

$$\begin{aligned}
\dot{\mathbf{v}} &= \frac{\mathbf{F}}{m} \\
&= -\frac{\mu}{r^2} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\
&= -\frac{\mu}{r^3} \mathbf{r}
\end{aligned} \tag{2.4.1}$$

2.4.2 Rate of change of $\mathbf{K}$

We will firstly define a vector which we will label $\mathbf{K}$ which is the vector product of the velocity vector and the specific angular momentum vector. The vector $\mathbf{K}$ doesn't have any special significance by itself, we're introducing it now for book keeping purposes here to help keep track of the steps in the derivation.

We will now look how this quantity $\mathbf{K}$ changes with respect to time.

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} &= \frac{d}{dt} (\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}) \\
&= \frac{d\mathbf{v}}{dt} \times \mathbf{h} + \mathbf{v} \times \frac{d\mathbf{h}}{dt}
\end{aligned} \tag{2.4.2}$$

since we have already shown that the rate of change of angular momentum is zero³ our above equation simplifies to

$$\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} = \dot{\mathbf{v}} \times \mathbf{h} \tag{2.4.3}$$

We can now substitute in equation 2.4.1⁴ for $\dot{\mathbf{v}}$, leaving us with

$$\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} = -\frac{\mu}{r^3} \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{h} \tag{2.4.4}$$

³equation 1.2.4 on page 2

⁴page 9

Recall that $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}$ leading to

$$\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} = -\frac{\mu}{r^3} \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v} \quad (2.4.5)$$

Next we can use the triple vector product expansion⁵ to expand $\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}$

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{\mathbf{K}} &= -\frac{\mu}{r^3} [(\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v})\mathbf{r} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{r})\mathbf{v}] \\ &= -\frac{\mu}{r^3} [(\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v})\mathbf{r} - r^2\mathbf{v}] \\ &= \frac{\mu}{r^3} [r^2\mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v})\mathbf{r}] \end{aligned} \quad (2.4.6)$$

2.4.3 Rate of change of the unit position vector

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d}{dt}\hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{d}{dt} \frac{\mathbf{r}}{r} \\ &= \frac{\dot{\mathbf{r}}r - \mathbf{r}\dot{r}}{r^2} \\ &= \frac{\mathbf{v} - \dot{r}\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r} \end{aligned} \quad (2.4.7)$$

where we have used the quotient rule⁶

Let's look at the rate of change of the magnitude of the position vector for a moment

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{dr}{dt} &= \frac{d}{dt}(\sqrt{r^2}) \\ &= \frac{d\sqrt{u}}{du} \frac{du}{dt} \\ &= \frac{1}{2\sqrt{u}} \frac{du}{dt} \end{aligned} \quad (2.4.8)$$

⁵equation A.2.1 on page 65

⁶equation A.3.1 on page 66

where we have introduced $u = r^2$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \dot{r} &= \frac{1}{2\sqrt{u}} \frac{du}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{1}{2\sqrt{r^2}} \frac{dr^2}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{1}{2r} \frac{d}{dt}(\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{r}) \\
 &= \frac{1}{2r} (\dot{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \mathbf{r} + \mathbf{r} \cdot \dot{\mathbf{r}}) \\
 &= \frac{2\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{2r} \\
 &= \frac{\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{r}
 \end{aligned} \tag{2.4.9}$$

we can now put this result back into equation 2.4.7⁷

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{d}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{\mathbf{v} - \dot{r} \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r} \\
 &= \frac{\mathbf{v} - \frac{\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{r} \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r} \\
 &= \frac{r^2 \mathbf{v} - \frac{\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{r} \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r^2} \\
 &= \frac{r^2 \mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}) r \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{r^3} \\
 &= \frac{r^2 \mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \mathbf{r}}{r^3}
 \end{aligned} \tag{2.4.10}$$

If we now multiply through by μ

$$\mu \frac{d}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{\mu}{r^2} [r^2 \mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \mathbf{r}] \tag{2.4.11}$$

Now if we compare to equation 2.4.6⁸

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⁸page 10

$$\begin{aligned}
\mu \frac{d}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \frac{\mu}{r^2} [r^2 \mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \mathbf{r}] \\
\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} &= \frac{\mu}{r^3} [r^2 \mathbf{v} - (\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}) \mathbf{r}]
\end{aligned}
\tag{2.4.12}$$

As you can see both are equal so we can equate them

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} &= \mu \frac{d}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\
\frac{d\mathbf{K}}{dt} - \mu \frac{d}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \mathbf{0} \\
\frac{d}{dt} [\mathbf{K} - \mu \hat{\mathbf{r}}] &= 0
\end{aligned}
\tag{2.4.13}$$

This shows that the vector $\mathbf{K} - \mu \hat{\mathbf{r}}$ is a constant.
The eccentricity vector is defined as

$$\mathbf{e} = \frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{r}}
\tag{2.4.14}$$

Which is just the vector we had multiplied by $\frac{1}{\mu}$ and so is also a constant. We will see later why this form in particular is chosen, for now it is enough to know that it is a third constant of the motion.

Chapter 3

Orbital Plane

3.1 Introduction

In this chapter we're going to start by determining the vectors that can define the orbital plane.

3.2 Direction of Angular Momentum

Firstly we will start with the fact that the angular momentum is a constant. This means the motion must be in a plane normal to the angular momentum. If the motion wasn't within the plane then the direction of the angular momentum would change, and so it would no longer be constant. This means the angular momentum vector determines the normal to the plane.

3.3 Direction of the Eccentricity Vector

When the orbiting body is at periapsis the velocity is perpendicular to the position vector. This is because the periapsis is defined as the point of closest approach to the central body. If the veloc-

ity at that point were not perpendicular to the position vector, it would have a radial component either toward or away from the central mass.

A radial component toward the central mass would imply that the particle continues to approach the central mass after this point, so it is not yet at periapsis.

A radial component away from the central mass would imply that the particle was closer to the focus at an earlier time.

Both possibilities contradict the assumption that the point is the periapsis. Hence the velocity at periapsis has no radial component and must be perpendicular to the position vector.

We will label the position vector when it is at periapsis $\mathbf{p}$, we also know that the velocity vector at periapsis $\mathbf{v}_p$ is perpendicular to the periapsis so $\mathbf{p} \cdot \mathbf{v}_p = 0$.

We can feed this into the eccentricity vector

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{e} &= \frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\
 &= \frac{\mathbf{v}_p \times \mathbf{p} \times \mathbf{v}_p}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{p}} \\
 &= \frac{(\mathbf{v}_p \cdot \mathbf{v}_p)\mathbf{p} - (\mathbf{v}_p \cdot \mathbf{p})\mathbf{v}_p}{\mu} - \frac{\mathbf{p}}{p} \\
 &= \left[\frac{v_p^2}{\mu} - \frac{1}{p} \right] \mathbf{p}
 \end{aligned} \tag{3.3.1}$$

This shows that the eccentricity vector is directed towards the periapsis vector.

3.4 Orbital Plane Basis Vectors

We now have two vectors that are perpendicular, one in the orbital plane directed towards the periapsis and another which is normal to it. We can create a third vector by taking the vector product

of the unit periapsis¹ and the unit angular momentum vector. We will label this vector $\mathbf{q}$.

$$\mathbf{q} = \frac{\mathbf{e} \times \mathbf{h}}{eh} \quad (3.4.1)$$

So now we have a set of basis vectors for the orbital plane $(\hat{\mathbf{p}}, \hat{\mathbf{q}}, \hat{\mathbf{h}})$

¹or equivalently the unit eccentricity vector

Chapter 4

Geometry of an Ellipse

4.1 The String Construction

One method of drawing an ellipse is to take a string of fixed length pinned to the two focus points of the ellipse. We can use this method to derive the standard equations for an ellipse. We will first start by setting up the geometry.

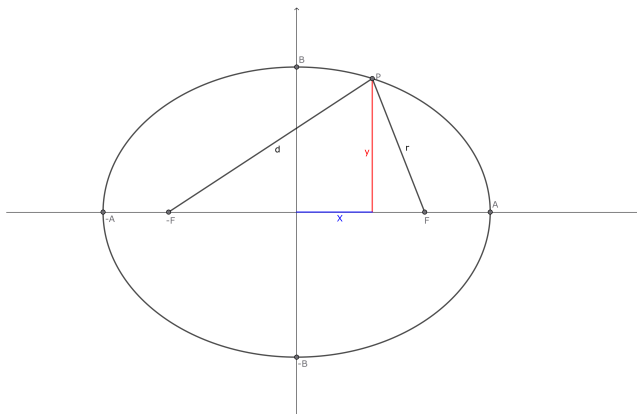


Figure 4.1: The string method of constructing an ellipse

We will work in a two dimensional Cartesian coordinate system with an ellipse centered at the origin and orientated so that it's

semi-major axis is directed along the x-axis and it's semi-minor axis orientated with the y axis. The two focus points F and $-F$ are located on the x-axis a distance f away from the origin, so that $F = (f, 0)$ and $-F = (-f, 0)$. Let P be an arbitrary point on the ellipse with coordinates $P = (X, y)$ ¹. The ellipse has semi-major axis length A and semi-minor axis length B , so that $-A \leq X \leq A$ and $-B \leq y \leq B$. Let r be the distance from F to P and d be the distance from $-F$ to P and let the sum of these be S , so that

$$S = r + d \quad (4.1.1)$$

where

$$\begin{aligned} r &= \sqrt{(X - f)^2 + y^2} \\ d &= \sqrt{(X + f)^2 + y^2} \end{aligned} \quad (4.1.2)$$

4.1.1 Special cases and useful results

From the construction method, we know that the sum is fixed. We can find it's exact value by considering P when $y = 0$ and $X = A$, so that

$$\begin{aligned} r &= \sqrt{(A - f)^2 + 0^2} \\ &= \sqrt{(A - f)^2} \\ &= A - f \\ d &= \sqrt{(A + f)^2 + 0^2} \\ &= \sqrt{(A + f)^2} \\ &= A + f \\ S &= r + d \\ &= A - f + A + f \\ S &= 2A \end{aligned} \quad (4.1.3)$$

¹We use X rather than x here to avoid confusion with a later definition of x as a distance measured from the focus F

This shows that the string must be twice the length of the semi-major axis to work.

Another interesting result is obtained when we look at the point $P = (0, B)$

$$\begin{aligned}
 r &= \sqrt{(0 - f)^2 + B^2} \\
 &= \sqrt{f^2 + B^2} \\
 d &= \sqrt{(0 + f)^2 + B^2} \\
 &= \sqrt{f^2 + B^2} \\
 S &= 2\sqrt{f^2 + B^2}
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.4}$$

since we now know that $S = 2A$ we can substitute for S

$$\begin{aligned}
 S &= 2\sqrt{f^2 + B^2} \\
 2A &= 2\sqrt{f^2 + B^2} \\
 A &= \sqrt{f^2 + B^2} \\
 A^2 &= f^2 + B^2
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.5}$$

You are more likely to see this stated as $B = A\sqrt{1 - e^2}$ where e or the eccentricity is defined to be

$$e = \frac{f}{A} \tag{4.1.6}$$

so that $f = eA$

4.1.2 Equation of an ellipse

Now we know the value of S we can look for a general equation that links X and y . Firstly we write out the sum in full

$$\begin{aligned}
 S &= r + d \\
 2A &= \sqrt{(X - f)^2 + y^2} + \sqrt{(X + f)^2 + y^2} \\
 2A - \sqrt{(X - f)^2 + y^2} &= \sqrt{(X + f)^2 + y^2}
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.7}$$

Now we square both sides to get rid of the first square root

$$\begin{aligned}
 \left(2A - \sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2}\right)^2 &= (X+f)^2 + y^2 \\
 4A^2 - 4A\sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} + (X-f)^2 + \cancel{y^2} &= (X+f)^2 + \cancel{y^2} \\
 4A^2 - 4A\sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} + \cancel{X^2} - \cancel{2Xf} + \cancel{f^2} &= \cancel{X^2} + \cancel{2Xf} + \cancel{f^2} \\
 4A^2 - 4A\sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} &= 4Xf \\
 A^2 - A\sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} &= fX \\
 A^2 - fX &= A\sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} \\
 A - \frac{fX}{A} &= \sqrt{(X-f)^2 + y^2} \\
 &\quad (4.1.8)
 \end{aligned}$$

Once again we square both sides to remove the square root

$$\begin{aligned}
 \left(A - \frac{fX}{A}\right)^2 &= (X-f)^2 + y^2 \\
 A^2 - 2\cancel{A}\frac{fX}{\cancel{A}} + \left(\frac{f}{A}\right)^2 X^2 &= X^2 - 2fX + f^2 + y^2 \\
 A^2 - \cancel{2fX} + \left(\frac{f}{A}\right)^2 X^2 &= X^2 - \cancel{2fX} + f^2 + y^2 \\
 A^2 - f^2 &= \left(1 - \left(\frac{f}{A}\right)^2\right) X^2 + y^2 \\
 &= \frac{A^2 - f^2}{A^2} X^2 + y^2 \\
 1 &= \frac{X^2}{A^2} + \frac{y^2}{A^2 - f^2}
 \end{aligned}$$

This further simplifies if we use equation 4.1.5² which with some rearrangement gives $B^2 = A^2 - f^2$.

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And so we get the typical form of the equation of an ellipse

$$1 = \frac{X^2}{A^2} + \frac{y^2}{B^2} \quad (4.1.9)$$

4.1.3 Equation for an ellipse in polar form

Here we are going to look at the equation of an ellipse in polar co-ordinates with the positive focus at the origin. The closest point³ lies along the positive x axis. This is the same system as we have been working with but shifted along the x axis so that the focus is at the origin, alternatively we can continue to use our centred ellipse but measure everything from the positive focus. This is in fact what we will do here and is also why we have made the distinction between the X coordinate and the x coordinate. Before looking at the relationship between X and x , we will look at the polar angle for an ellipse⁴.

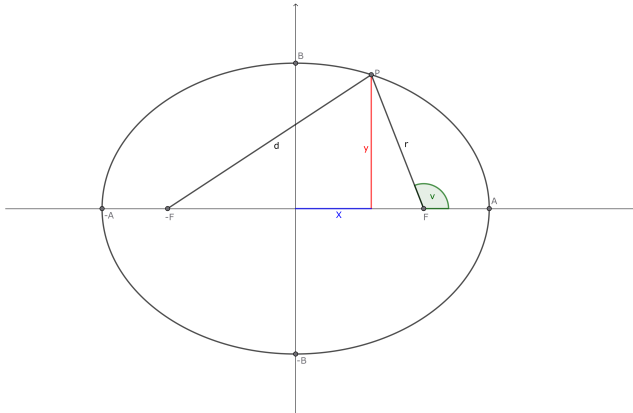


Figure 4.2: The polar angle for an ellipse

As you can see from Figure 4.2 we can determine the point P based on the polar angle ν

³Which as we will see later is called the periapsis for an orbit

⁴for orbits, this angle is called the true anomaly

$$\begin{aligned} X &= f + r \cos \nu \\ y &= r \sin \nu \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.10}$$

we can also define x now also

$$x = r \cos \nu \tag{4.1.11}$$

Going back to the sum equation⁵

$$\begin{aligned} S &= r + d \\ 2A - r &= d \\ (2A - r)^2 &= d^2 \\ (2A - r)^2 &= (X + f)^2 + y^2 \\ 4A^2 - 4Ar + r^2 &= X^2 + 2Xf + f^2 + y^2 \\ 4A^2 - 4Ar + r^2 &= X^2 + 2Xf + f^2 + y^2 \\ &= (f + r \cos \nu)^2 + 2f^2 + 2fr \cos \nu + f^2 + y^2 \\ &= f^2 + 2fr \cos \nu + r^2 \cos^2 \nu + 2f^2 + 2fr \cos \nu + f^2 + y^2 \\ &= 4f^2 + 4fr \cos \nu + r^2 \cos^2 \nu + y^2 \\ &= 4f^2 + 4fr \cos \nu + r^2 \cos^2 \nu + r^2 \sin^2 \nu \\ &= 4f^2 + 4fr \cos \nu + r^2 \\ 4A^2 - 4Ar + \cancel{r^2} &= 4f^2 + 4fr \cos \nu + \cancel{r^2} \\ 4A^2 - 4Ar &= 4f^2 + 4fr \cos \nu \\ A^2 - Ar &= f^2 + fr \cos \nu \\ A^2 - f^2 &= Ar + fr \cos \nu \\ A^2 - f^2 &= r(A + f \cos \nu) \\ r &= \frac{A^2 - f^2}{A + f \cos \nu} \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.12}$$

We can do a little further simplifying by using Equation 4.1.6⁶

⁵Equation 4.1.3 on page 18

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$$\begin{aligned}
 r &= \frac{A^2 - f^2}{A + f \cos \nu} \\
 &= \frac{A^2 - e^2 A^2}{A + eA \cos \nu} \\
 &= \frac{A^2(1 - e^2)}{A(1 + e \cos \nu)} \\
 &= \frac{A(1 - e^2)}{1 + e \cos \nu}
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.1.13}$$

Which is the standard form.

4.2 The Auxiliary Circle

Another parameterisation for an ellipse comes from looking at the relationship to a circle. In other words, an ellipse can also be seen as a flattened circle.

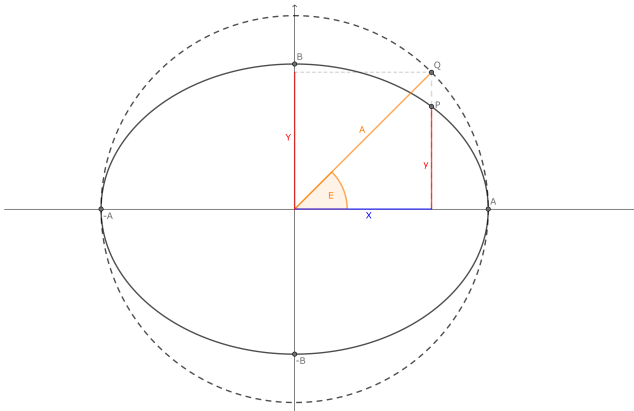


Figure 4.3: The ellipse and the auxiliary circle

Consider a circle with radius A which is centred on the ellipse with a semi-major axis of length A and a semi-minor axis of length B , as in Figure 4.3. The circle is known as the Auxiliary Circle.

We can define a point Q on the circle as $(A \cos E, A \sin E)$ so that the line from the origin to Q has an angle E^7 with the x axis.

We can now choose point P that is on the ellipse so that Q and P share the same x coordinate.

$$X = A \cos E \quad (4.2.1)$$

We can work out the corresponding y coordinate by using the equation of an ellipse⁸.

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{X^2}{A^2} + \frac{y^2}{B^2} &= 1 \\ \frac{A^2 \cos^2 E}{A^2} + \frac{y^2}{B^2} &= 1 \\ \cos^2 E + \frac{y^2}{B^2} &= 1 \\ \frac{y^2}{B^2} &= 1 - \cos^2 E \\ \frac{y^2}{B^2} &= \sin^2 E \\ y^2 &= B^2 \sin^2 E \\ y &= B \sin E \end{aligned} \quad (4.2.2)$$

Which leads to one of the standard parameterisations $P = (A \cos E, B \sin E)$

4.2.1 String Construction Revisited

We can use the string construction again to obtain the distance from the positive focus to point P , which we have called r , in terms of the angle E now. Firstly we recall the sum of the lengths, equation 4.1.1⁹ which we can rearrange to get the length r

$$r = S - d \quad (4.2.3)$$

⁷This angle is called the eccentric anomaly in terms of orbits

⁸Equation 4.1.9 on page 21

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Also we showed that the sum $S = 2A$ via equation 4.1.3¹⁰

$$r = 2A - d \quad (4.2.4)$$

We can now replace d with equation 4.1.2¹¹

$$\begin{aligned} r &= 2A - \sqrt{(X + f)^2 + y^2} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{X^2 + 2fX + f^2 + y^2} \end{aligned} \quad (4.2.5)$$

We can now substitute in the new parameterisation we obtained for P , namely equations 4.2.1¹² and 4.2.2¹³.

$$\begin{aligned} r &= 2A - \sqrt{X^2 + 2fX + f^2 + y^2} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 \cos^2 E + 2fA \cos E + f^2 + B^2 \sin^2 E} \end{aligned} \quad (4.2.6)$$

we can now replace B using equation 4.1.5¹⁴ by noting that $B^2 = A^2 - f^2$

$$\begin{aligned} r &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 \cos^2 E + 2fA \cos E + f^2 + B^2 \sin^2 E} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 \cos^2 E + 2fA \cos E + f^2 + (A^2 - f^2) \sin^2 E} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 \cos^2 E + 2fA \cos E + f^2 + A^2 \sin^2 E - f^2 \sin^2 E} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 \cos^2 E + A^2 \sin^2 E + 2fA \cos E + f^2 - f^2 \sin^2 E} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 + 2fA \cos E + f^2(1 - \sin^2 E)} \\ &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 + 2fA \cos E + f^2 \cos^2 E} \end{aligned} \quad (4.2.7)$$

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via equation 4.1.6¹⁵ we can replace $f = eA$

$$\begin{aligned}
 r &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 + 2fA \cos E + f^2 \cos^2 E} \\
 &= 2A - \sqrt{A^2 + 2eA^2 \cos E + e^2 A^2 \cos^2 E} \\
 &= 2A - A\sqrt{1 + 2e \cos E + e^2 \cos^2 E} \\
 &= 2A - A\sqrt{(1 + e \cos E)^2} \\
 &= 2A - A(1 + e \cos E) \\
 &= 2A - A - eA \cos E \\
 &= A(1 - e \cos E)
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.2.8}$$

4.3 The Apses

The apses are the closest and furthest point from the positive focus of the ellipse. The periapsis is the closest point and the apoapsis is the farthest point. We will lable these p and a respectively.

As we can see from Figure 4.4 that the periapsis has a length of $p = A - f$ and the apoapsis has a length of $a = A + f$. We can put these in terms of the semi-major axis and the eccentricity by using equation 4.1.6¹⁶

$$\begin{aligned}
 p &= A(1 - e) \\
 a &= A(1 + e)
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.3.1}$$

Taking the sum we get

$$a + p = A(1 - e) + A(1 + e) = 2A \tag{4.3.2}$$

Taking the difference we get

$$a - p = A(1 - e) - A(1 + e) = 2eA = 2f \tag{4.3.3}$$

Taking the product we get

$$ap = A(1 - e)A(1 + e) = A^2(1 - e^2) = A^2 - f^2 = B^2 \tag{4.3.4}$$

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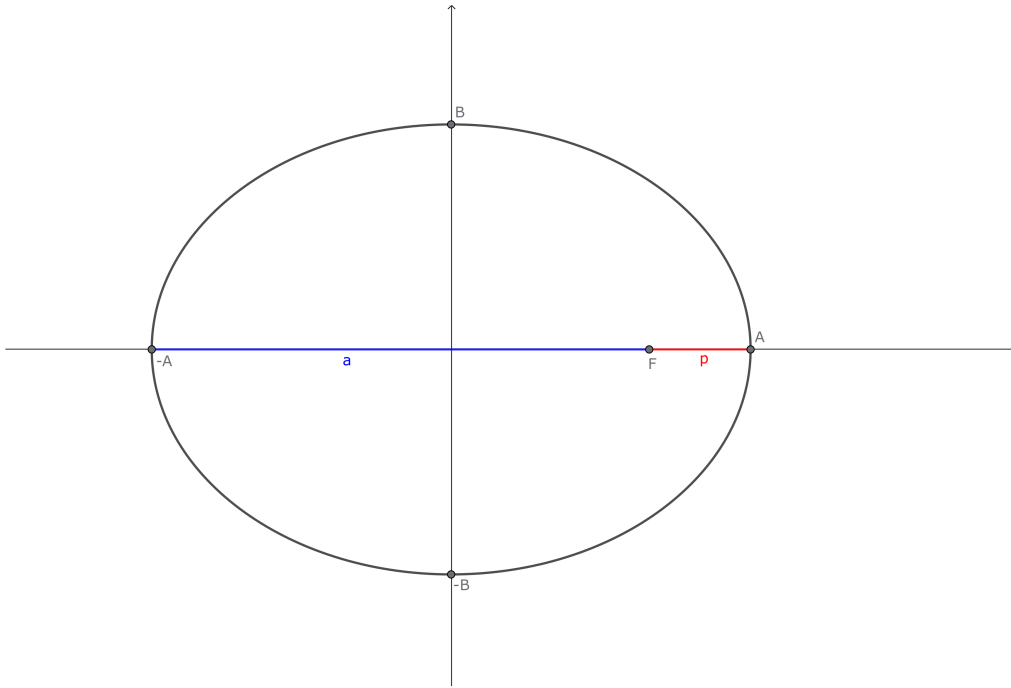


Figure 4.4: The ellipse with the apses highlighted

4.4 Relationship between angles

Here we will show that there is a relationship between the angles ν in Figure 4.2¹⁷ and E in Figure 4.3¹⁸. In terms of orbits as we will see later, ν is called the true anomaly and E is the eccentric anomaly.

We start by looking at the tangent of ν .

$$\tan \nu = \frac{y}{x} \quad (4.4.1)$$

Let's firstly look at y , we can start with the y part of equation

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4.1.10¹⁹ and equation 4.2.2²⁰

$$\begin{aligned} y &= r \sin \nu \\ &= B \sin E \\ &= A\sqrt{1 - e^2} \sin E \end{aligned} \tag{4.4.2}$$

We have used equation 4.1.5²¹ and equation 4.1.6²² to replace B with $A\sqrt{1 - e^2}$

Next we can look at x , using the X part of equation 4.1.10²³ and 4.2.1²⁴, we get

$$\begin{aligned} x &= r \cos \nu \\ &= A \cos E - f \\ &= A \cos E - eA \\ &= A(\cos E - e) \end{aligned} \tag{4.4.3}$$

where once again we have used equation 4.1.6²⁵ to replace f with eA .

We can now put these into

$$\begin{aligned} \tan \nu &= \frac{y}{x} \\ &= \frac{A\sqrt{1 - e^2} \sin E}{A(\cos E - e)} \\ &= \frac{\sqrt{1 - e^2} \sin E}{\cos E - e} \end{aligned} \tag{4.4.4}$$

Here we can use the half tan formulas A.1.1²⁶ and A.1.2²⁷ to re-

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place the sine and cosine

$$\begin{aligned}
 \tan \nu &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} \sin E}{\cos E - e} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} \frac{2 \tan \frac{E}{2}}{1+\tan^2 \frac{E}{2}}}{\frac{1-\tan^2 \frac{E}{2}}{1+\tan^2 \frac{E}{2}} - e} \tag{4.4.5}
 \end{aligned}$$

Because the next steps can get a little messy, we'll introduce some variables to help, let $t = \tan \frac{E}{2}$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \tan \nu &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} \frac{2t}{1+t^2}}{\frac{1-t^2}{1+t^2} - e} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} \frac{2t}{1+t^2}}{\frac{1-t^2-e-et^2}{1+t^2}} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} 2t}{1-t^2-e-et^2} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} 2t}{1-e-(1+e)t^2} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{1-e^2} 2t}{(1+e) \left(\frac{1-e}{1+e} - t^2 \right)} \\
 &= \frac{\sqrt{(1-e)(1+e)} 2t}{(1+e) \left(\frac{1-e}{1+e} - t^2 \right)} \\
 &= \sqrt{\frac{1-e}{1+e}} \frac{2t}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{1-e}{1+e}} \right)^2 - t^2} \tag{4.4.6}
 \end{aligned}$$

Again for ease, let $\alpha = \sqrt{\frac{1-e}{1+e}}$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \tan \nu &= \sqrt{\frac{1-e}{1+e}} \frac{2t}{\left(\sqrt{\frac{1-e}{1+e}}\right)^2 - t^2} \\
 &= \alpha \frac{2t}{\alpha^2 - t^2} \\
 &= \alpha \frac{2t}{\alpha^2 \left(1 - \frac{t^2}{\alpha^2}\right)} \\
 &= \frac{2\frac{t}{\alpha}}{\left(1 - \frac{t^2}{\alpha^2}\right)}
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.4.7}$$

Now we now use Equation A.1.3²⁸ to replace $\tan \nu$ with $\tan \frac{\nu}{2}$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \tan \nu &= \frac{2\frac{t}{\alpha}}{\left(1 - \frac{t^2}{\alpha^2}\right)} \\
 \frac{2 \tan \frac{\nu}{2}}{1 - \tan^2 \frac{\nu}{2}} &= \frac{2\frac{t}{\alpha}}{\left(1 - \frac{t^2}{\alpha^2}\right)}
 \end{aligned} \tag{4.4.8}$$

you can see that

$$\tan \frac{\nu}{2} = \sqrt{\frac{1+e}{1-e}} \tan \frac{E}{2} \tag{4.4.9}$$

Chapter 5

Physics and Geometry

5.1 Introduction

In this chapter we will look at the connection between the geometry of ellipses and the physical constants that we've shown previously.

5.2 Elliptical Orbits

Here we will show that an ellipse is a solution to the equations of motion.

5.3 The Apses

The apses are the closest and furthest point from the focus in the orbit. In other words they are the maximum and minimum radius. At the apses

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \dot{r} = 0 \tag{5.3.1}$$

We can then use equation 2.4.9¹ to show that the velocity is perpendicular to the radius at the apses.

$$\begin{aligned}\dot{r} &= \frac{\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{r} \\ 0 &= \frac{\mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}}{r} \\ 0 &= \mathbf{r} \cdot \mathbf{v}\end{aligned}\tag{5.3.2}$$

since the scalar product is zero, the two vectors must be perpendicular².

5.3.1 Angular Momentum

If the radius and velocity are perpendicular at the apses, then the magnitude of the specific angular momentum is

$$h = pv_p = av_a\tag{5.3.3}$$

where v_p is the velocity at the periapsis and v_a is the velocity at apoapsis.

5.3.2 Energy

We can now look at the specific total energy again, firstly at periapsis

$$\begin{aligned}\epsilon &= \frac{v_p^2}{2} - \frac{\mu}{p} \\ &= \frac{h^2}{2p^2} - \frac{\mu}{p}\end{aligned}\tag{5.3.4}$$

then at apoapsis

$$\begin{aligned}\epsilon &= \frac{v_a^2}{2} - \frac{\mu}{a} \\ &= \frac{h^2}{2a^2} - \frac{\mu}{a}\end{aligned}\tag{5.3.5}$$

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²or zero, but we are looking at non-zero solutions in particular

Since total energy is a constant these must be equal

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{h^2}{2p^2} - \frac{\mu}{p} &= \frac{h^2}{2a^2} - \frac{\mu}{a} \\
 \frac{h^2}{2p^2} - \frac{h^2}{2a^2} &= \frac{\mu}{p} - \frac{\mu}{a} \\
 \frac{a^2 h^2}{2a^2 p^2} - \frac{p^2 h^2}{2a^2 p^2} &= \frac{a\mu}{ap} - \frac{p\mu}{ap} \\
 \frac{a^2 h^2 - p^2 h^2}{2a^2 p^2} &= \frac{a\mu - p\mu}{ap} \\
 h^2 \frac{a^2 - p^2}{2ap} &= (a - p)\mu \\
 h^2 &= \frac{2ap(a - p)}{a^2 - p^2} \mu \\
 &= \frac{2ap(a - p)}{(a - p)(a + p)} \mu \\
 &= \frac{2ap}{a + p} \mu
 \end{aligned} \tag{5.3.6}$$

5.3.3 Velocity

We now have an equation 5.2.6³ for the specific angular momentum based purely on the central mass and the geometry of the orbit. We can use this to calculate velocities at the periapsis

$$v_p = \frac{h}{p} = \frac{\sqrt{\mu}}{p} \sqrt{\frac{2ap}{a + p}} \tag{5.3.7}$$

and for the apoapsis

$$v_a = \frac{h}{a} = \frac{\sqrt{\mu}}{a} \sqrt{\frac{2ap}{a + p}} \tag{5.3.8}$$

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5.3.4 Semi-Major Axis

We can feed this result back into equation 5.2.4⁴

$$\begin{aligned}
 \epsilon &= \frac{h^2}{2p^2} - \frac{\mu}{p} \\
 &= \frac{2ap}{2p^2(a+p)}\mu - \frac{\mu}{p} \\
 &= \frac{\mu}{p} \left(\frac{a}{a+p} - 1 \right) \\
 &= \frac{\mu}{p} \left(\frac{a}{a+p} - \frac{a+p}{a+p} \right) \\
 &= \frac{\mu}{p} \left(\frac{a - a - p}{a+p} \right) \\
 &= \frac{\mu}{p} \left(\frac{-p}{a+p} \right) \\
 &= \frac{-\mu}{a+p}
 \end{aligned} \tag{5.3.9}$$

Using equation 4.3.2⁵ we can replace the $a+p$ term

$$\begin{aligned}
 \epsilon &= \frac{-\mu}{2A} \\
 A &= \frac{-\mu}{2\epsilon}
 \end{aligned} \tag{5.3.10}$$

5.3.5 Eccentricity

We will now use the results of equation 5.2.6⁶

$$h^2 = \frac{2ap}{a+p}\mu$$

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as before we can use equation 4.3.2⁷ to replace $a + p$, additionally we can use equation 4.3.4⁸ to replace the ap term.

$$\begin{aligned} h^2 &= \frac{2A^2(1 - e^2)}{2A}\mu \\ &= A(1 - e^2)\mu \end{aligned} \quad (5.3.11)$$

now we can use equation 5.2.10⁹ to replace A

$$\begin{aligned} h^2 &= A(1 - e^2)\mu \\ &= \frac{-\mu}{2\epsilon}(1 - e^2)\mu \\ \frac{2\epsilon h^2}{\mu} &= e^2 - 1 \\ 1 + \frac{2\epsilon h^2}{\mu^2} &= e^2 \end{aligned} \quad (5.3.12)$$

We could now calculate a and p from the energy and angular momentum, by first using those to calculate A and e , and then using equation 4.3.1¹⁰. We will not do this here, this is more a note to say it can be done. When we look at using initial conditions to calculate various constants, we will return to the calculation then.

5.4 Eccentricity Vector

Now we will return to the eccentricity vector given by equation 2.4.14¹¹.

$$\mathbf{e} = \frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{r}}$$

In the chapter we introduced the eccentricity vector, we claimed that it's length was the same as the eccentricity, which is why it

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was called the eccentricity vector. At the time we did not show this to be the case, but now we have all the machinery needed to show it to be the case.

We will need one result that we haven't yet seen, that is the squared magnitude of $\mathbf{h}$, or at least in form we haven't seen yet

$$\begin{aligned} h^2 &= \mathbf{h} \cdot \mathbf{h} \\ &= \mathbf{h} \cdot (\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}) \end{aligned} \tag{5.4.1}$$

We can use equation A.2.2¹² to get the result

$$\begin{aligned} h^2 &= \mathbf{h} \cdot (\mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}) \\ &= \mathbf{r} \cdot (\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}) \end{aligned} \tag{5.4.2}$$

Not a very exciting result yet, but it will come into play now. Lets now look at the thing we actually want to know, the magnitude of the eccentricity vector.

$$\begin{aligned} e^2 &= \mathbf{e} \cdot \mathbf{e} \\ &= \left(\frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{r}} \right) \cdot \left(\frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} - \hat{\mathbf{r}} \right) \\ &= \left(\frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} \right)^2 - 2 \frac{\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}}{\mu} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}} + \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\ &= \frac{|\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}|^2}{\mu^2} - 2 \frac{(\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}) \cdot \hat{\mathbf{r}}}{\mu} + 1 \\ &= \frac{|\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}|^2}{\mu^2} - 2 \frac{(\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}) \cdot \mathbf{r}}{\mu r} + 1 \end{aligned} \tag{5.4.3}$$

We can use our previous equation 5.3.2¹³ now, as well as the fact that $\mathbf{v}$ and $\mathbf{h}$ are perpendicular by construction, since $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{v}$,

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so it is perpendicular to both $\mathbf{r}$ and $\mathbf{v}$. This means $|\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}| = vh$.

$$\begin{aligned}
 e^2 &= \frac{|\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}|^2}{\mu^2} - 2 \frac{(\mathbf{v} \times \mathbf{h}) \cdot \mathbf{r}}{\mu r} + 1 \\
 &= \frac{v^2 h^2}{\mu^2} - 2 \frac{h^2}{\mu r} + 1 \\
 &= \frac{2v^2 h^2}{2\mu^2} - 2 \frac{h^2 \mu}{\mu^2 r} + 1 \\
 &= \frac{2h^2}{\mu^2} \left(\frac{v^2}{2} - \frac{\mu}{r} \right) + 1
 \end{aligned}
 \tag{5.4.4}$$

Notice how the part in the brackets is the same as equation 2.3.1¹⁴, this means we can replace the whole bracket with ϵ , leading to the result.

$$e^2 = \frac{2\epsilon h^2}{\mu^2} + 1$$

Which is the exact same form as equation 5.2.12¹⁵, this shows that the length of the eccentricity vector is in fact the same as the eccentricity.

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Chapter 6

Perifocal Coordinates

6.1 Introduction

In this chapter we will introduce the perifocal coordinate system and derive the equations of motion in this coordinate system. We will also establish the angular momentum, and total energy. Finally we will show that closed solutions to the equations of motion in the perifocal coordinate system are ellipses.

As a bonus, we will also revisit the eccentricity vector, and show how it relates to the solutions from this chapter.

6.2 Plane Polar Coordinates

In this section we will derive the equations of motion for an object acted upon by gravity in plane polar coordinates. To do this we will first consider plane polar coordinates themselves and the derivatives of the position vector within the coordinate system.

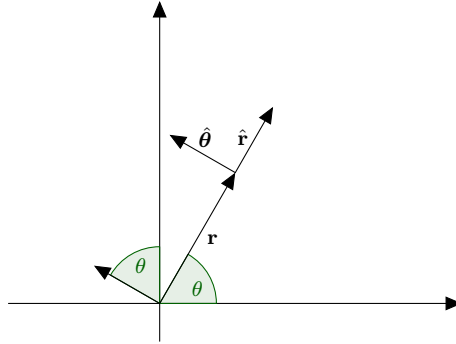


Figure 6.1: Position and unit vectors in plane polar coordinates

6.2.1 Polar unit vectors

The unit vectors of plane polar coordinates can be determined from the standard unit vectors as

$$\hat{\mathbf{r}} = \hat{\mathbf{i}} \cos(\theta) + \hat{\mathbf{j}} \sin(\theta) \quad (6.2.1)$$

$$\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = -\hat{\mathbf{i}} \sin(\theta) + \hat{\mathbf{j}} \cos(\theta) \quad (6.2.2)$$

Where r is the distance from the origin to the position or alternatively the length of the position vector, and θ is the angle between $\hat{\mathbf{i}}$ and $\mathbf{r}$. Since the unit vectors $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ and $\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$ depend on θ which changes with time, the unit vectors also change with time. We will begin by looking at the derivative of $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ with respect to time.

$$\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt} = \frac{d\theta}{dt} \frac{d}{d\theta} \hat{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{d\theta}{dt} [-\hat{\mathbf{i}} \sin(\theta) + \hat{\mathbf{j}} \cos(\theta)] = \frac{d\theta}{dt} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \quad (6.2.3)$$

where we have used equation 6.2.2 to replace the typical Cartesian coordinate unit vectors.

$$\frac{d\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}}{dt} = \frac{d\theta}{dt} \frac{d}{d\theta} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} = \frac{d\theta}{dt} [-\hat{\mathbf{i}} \cos(\theta) - \hat{\mathbf{j}} \sin(\theta)] = -\frac{d\theta}{dt} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (6.2.4)$$

Since $\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt}$ too depends on θ so is also time dependent.

$$\frac{d^2\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt^2} = \frac{d}{dt} \left[\frac{d\theta}{dt} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \right] = \frac{d^2\theta}{dt^2} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} + \frac{d\theta}{dt} \frac{d\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}}{dt} = \frac{d^2\theta}{dt^2} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} - \left(\frac{d\theta}{dt} \right)^2 \hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (6.2.5)$$

Polar unit vectors summary

The polar coordinate unit vectors are

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{\mathbf{r}} &= \hat{\mathbf{i}} \cos(\theta) + \hat{\mathbf{j}} \sin(\theta) \\ \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} &= -\hat{\mathbf{i}} \sin(\theta) + \hat{\mathbf{j}} \cos(\theta) \end{aligned}$$

With the first derivatives being

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt} &= \omega \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \\ \frac{d\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}}{dt} &= -\omega \hat{\mathbf{r}} \end{aligned}$$

And the second derivative of $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ being

$$\frac{d^2\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt^2} = \frac{d\omega}{dt} \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} - \omega^2 \hat{\mathbf{r}}$$

with $\omega = \frac{d\theta}{dt}$

6.2.2 Velocity and acceleration in polar coordinates

Here we will calculate the acceleration in terms of the polar unit vectors.

Position

Starting with the position vector

$$\mathbf{r} = r\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (6.2.6)$$

This is the length of the position vector in the direction of $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$.

Velocity

The first derivative will be the velocity of the position vector in terms of the polar unit vectors

$$\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} = \frac{dr}{dt}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt} = \frac{dr}{dt}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \quad (6.2.7)$$

The velocity is the sum of the radial velocity in the radial direction $\dot{r}$ and the angular part of the velocity $r\omega$ in the angular direction.

Acceleration

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d^2\mathbf{r}}{dt^2} &= \frac{d^2r}{dt^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + \frac{dr}{dt}\frac{d\hat{\mathbf{r}}}{dt} + \frac{dr}{dt}\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} + r\frac{d\omega}{dt}\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} + r\omega\frac{d\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}}{dt} \\ &= \frac{d^2r}{dt^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + \frac{dr}{dt}\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} + \frac{dr}{dt}\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} + r\frac{d\omega}{dt}\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} - r\omega^2\hat{\mathbf{r}} \\ &= \left[\frac{d^2r}{dt^2} - r\omega^2\right]\hat{\mathbf{r}} + \left[2\frac{dr}{dt}\omega + r\frac{d\omega}{dt}\right]\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \end{aligned} \quad (6.2.8)$$

Acceleration in polar coordinates summary

The position vector

$$\mathbf{r} = r\hat{\mathbf{r}}$$

Velocity

$$\frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} = \frac{dr}{dt}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$$

Acceleration

$$\frac{d^2\mathbf{r}}{dt^2} = \left[\frac{d^2r}{dt^2} - r\omega^2 \right] \hat{\mathbf{r}} + \left[2\frac{dr}{dt}\omega + r\frac{d\omega}{dt} \right] \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}}$$

6.3 Gravity

6.3.1 Gravity as a central force

The force between two particles a distance r apart with mass M and m respectively is given by

$$\mathbf{F} = -\frac{GMm}{r^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (6.3.1)$$

The acceleration on the particle of mass m due to the force of gravity between the two particles is

$$\ddot{\mathbf{r}} = \frac{\mathbf{F}}{m} = -\frac{GM}{r^2}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \quad (6.3.2)$$

Using equation 6.2.8 we can split the acceleration into radial and angular parts

$$-\frac{GM}{r^2} = \ddot{r} - r\omega^2 \quad (6.3.3)$$

$$0 = r\ddot{\theta} + 2\dot{r}\dot{\theta} \quad (6.3.4)$$

6.4 Angular Momentum

The angular momentum of a particle is given by

$$\begin{aligned}
 \mathbf{L} &= \mathbf{r} \times \mathbf{p} \\
 &= m\mathbf{r} \times \frac{d\mathbf{r}}{dt} \\
 &= mr\hat{\mathbf{r}} \times \left[\dot{r}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \right] \\
 &= m \left[r\dot{r}\hat{\mathbf{r}} \times \hat{\mathbf{r}} + r^2\omega\hat{\mathbf{r}} \times \hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \right] \\
 &= mr^2\omega\hat{\mathbf{k}}
 \end{aligned} \tag{6.4.1}$$

We can also write this as $\mathbf{L} = l\hat{\mathbf{k}}$ where

$$l = mr^2\omega \tag{6.4.2}$$

6.4.1 Conservation Of Angular Momentum

We can show now that angular momentum is conserved under a central force by taking the derivative with respect to time.

$$\frac{d\mathbf{L}}{dt} = \frac{dl\hat{\mathbf{k}}}{dt} = \frac{dl}{dt}\hat{\mathbf{k}} \tag{6.4.3}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dl}{dt} &= m \frac{d}{dt} [r^2\omega] \\
 &= m \left[\frac{dr^2}{dt}\omega + r^2 \frac{d\omega}{dt} \right] \\
 &= m \left[\frac{dr^2}{dr} \frac{dr}{dt}\omega + r^2 \frac{d\omega}{dt} \right] \\
 &= m \left[2r \frac{dr}{dt}\omega + r^2 \frac{d\omega}{dt} \right] \\
 &= mr \left[2 \frac{dr}{dt}\omega + r \frac{d\omega}{dt} \right]
 \end{aligned} \tag{6.4.4}$$

The part inside the brackets is the angular acceleration which for a central force is zero¹ and so

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{dl}{dt} &= mr \times 0 \\ &= 0\end{aligned}\tag{6.4.5}$$

Which means that the angular momentum is constant as seen before.

6.5 Energy

6.5.1 Potential Energy

The potential energy is the work done in moving the particle from a radius of ∞ to r . So the work done is given by

$$\begin{aligned}U(r) &= \int_{\infty}^r \mathbf{F}(r') \cdot d\mathbf{r}' \\ U(r) &= \int_{\infty}^r -\frac{GMm}{r'^2} \hat{\mathbf{r}} \cdot dr' \hat{\mathbf{r}} \\ U(r) &= -GMm \int_{\infty}^r \frac{dr'}{r'^2} \\ U(r) &= -GMm \left[\frac{-1}{r'} \right]_{\infty}^r \\ U(r) &= GMm \left[\frac{1}{\infty} - \frac{1}{r} \right] \\ U(r) &= -\frac{GMm}{r}\end{aligned}\tag{6.5.1}$$

6.5.2 Kinetic Energy

The kinetic energy of a particle is given by

$$T(\dot{\mathbf{r}}) = \frac{1}{2} m \dot{\mathbf{r}} \cdot \dot{\mathbf{r}}\tag{6.5.2}$$

¹see equation 6.3.4

using equation 6.2.2 gives

$$\begin{aligned} T(\dot{r}) &= \frac{1}{2}m \left[\dot{r}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \right] \cdot \left[\dot{r}\hat{\mathbf{r}} + r\omega\hat{\boldsymbol{\theta}} \right] \\ &= \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{1}{2}mr^2\omega^2 \end{aligned} \quad (6.5.3)$$

we can also make the substitution using the magnitude of the angular momentum² $l = mr^2\omega$

$$\begin{aligned} l &= mr^2\omega \\ \omega &= \frac{l}{mr^2} \end{aligned} \quad (6.5.4)$$

using equation 6.5.4 in equation 6.5.3 leads to

$$\begin{aligned} T(\dot{r}) &= \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{1}{2}mr^2\omega^2 \\ &= \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{1}{2}mr^2 \frac{l^2}{m^2r^4} \\ &= \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} \end{aligned} \quad (6.5.5)$$

Total Energy

Finally the total energy can be found by putting together the equation for kinetic energy and potential energy

$$\begin{aligned} E(r, \dot{r}) &= T(\dot{r}) + U(r) \\ E(r, \dot{r}) &= \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} - \frac{GMm}{r} \end{aligned} \quad (6.5.6)$$

sometimes the last two terms of equation 6.5.6 are put together to form a new potential energy type term that is dependent only on the radius and the angular momentum.

²equation 6.4.2

6.5.3 Conservation of Total Energy

Just like with angular momentum we can show that total energy is conserved by taking the derivative with respect to time.

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{d}{dt} \left[\frac{1}{2} m \dot{r}^2 + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} - \frac{GMm}{r} \right] \\
 &= \frac{1}{2} m \frac{d\dot{r}^2}{dt} + \frac{l^2}{2m} \frac{dr^{-2}}{dt} - GMm \frac{dr^{-1}}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{1}{2} m \frac{d\dot{r}^2}{dr} \frac{dr}{dt} + \frac{l^2}{2m} \frac{dr^{-2}}{dr} \frac{dr}{dt} - GMm \frac{dr^{-1}}{dr} \frac{dr}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{1}{2} m (2\dot{r}) \ddot{r} + \frac{l^2}{2m} \left(\frac{-2}{r^3} \right) \dot{r} + \frac{GMm}{r^2} \dot{r} \\
 &= m\dot{r}\ddot{r} - \frac{l^2}{mr^3} \dot{r} + \frac{GMm}{r^2} \dot{r} \tag{6.5.7}
 \end{aligned}$$

using the magnitude of the angular momentum³ $l = mr^2\omega$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dE}{dt} &= m\dot{r}\ddot{r} - \frac{l^2}{mr^3} \dot{r} + \frac{GMm}{r^2} \dot{r} \\
 &= m\dot{r}\ddot{r} - \frac{m^2 r^4 \omega^2}{mr^3} \dot{r} + \frac{GMm}{r^2} \dot{r} \\
 &= m\dot{r}\ddot{r} - mr\omega^2 \dot{r} + \frac{GMm}{r^2} \dot{r} \\
 &= m\dot{r} \left[\ddot{r} - r\omega^2 + \frac{GM}{r^2} \right] \tag{6.5.8}
 \end{aligned}$$

using the radial part of the acceleration⁴ $-\frac{GM}{r^2} = \ddot{r} - r\omega^2$ we get

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dE}{dt} &= m\dot{r} \left[-\frac{GM}{r^2} + \frac{GM}{r^2} \right] \\
 &= m\dot{r} [0] \\
 &= 0 \tag{6.5.9}
 \end{aligned}$$

³equation 6.4.2

⁴equation 6.3.3

This then shows that the total energy does not change with respect to time, so is a constant and also conserved.

6.6 Elliptical Orbits

We can show that a general solution to the equations of motion is an ellipse.

6.6.1 Change of variables

Firstly we start by letting $r = \frac{1}{u}$, so that

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dr}{dt} &= \frac{du^{-1}}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{du^{-1}}{du} \frac{du}{dt} \\
 &= -\frac{1}{u^2} \frac{du}{dt} \\
 &= -r^2 \frac{du}{dt}
 \end{aligned} \tag{6.6.1}$$

next we introduce an ω by chain rule

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{dr}{dt} &= -r^2 \frac{du}{dt} \\
 \frac{dr}{dt} &= -r^2 \frac{du}{d\theta} \frac{d\theta}{dt} \\
 &= -r^2 \omega \frac{du}{d\theta}
 \end{aligned}$$

And using the magnitude of angular momentum⁵ $l = mr^2\omega$ or rearranging $\omega = \frac{l}{mr^2}$

⁵equation 6.4.2

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{dr}{dt} &= -r^2\omega\frac{du}{d\theta} \\
\frac{dr}{dt} &= -r^2\frac{l}{mr^2}\frac{du}{d\theta} \\
\frac{dr}{dt} &= -\frac{l}{m}\frac{du}{d\theta} \\
\frac{dr}{dt} &= -\frac{l}{m}\frac{du}{d\theta}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.2}$$

Differentiating again with respect to time gives

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{dr^2}{dt^2} &= -\frac{l}{m}\frac{d}{dt}\frac{du}{d\theta} \\
&= -\frac{l}{m}\frac{d\theta}{dt}\frac{d}{d\theta}\frac{du}{d\theta} \\
&= -\frac{l}{m}\omega\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.3}$$

We can substitute the magnitude of angular momentum⁶ $l = mr^2\omega$ again to get

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{dr^2}{dt^2} &= -\frac{l}{m}\omega\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} \\
&= -\frac{mr^2\omega}{m}\omega\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} \\
&= -r^2\omega^2\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.4}$$

We can now substitute this into the radial part of the acceleration⁷

⁶equation 6.4.2

⁷equation 6.3.3

$$\begin{aligned}
-\frac{GM}{r^2} &= \frac{d^2r}{dt^2} - r\omega^2 \\
&= -r^2\omega^2 \frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} - r\omega^2 \\
&= -r^2\omega^2 \left[\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + \frac{1}{r} \right] \\
GM &= r^4\omega^2 \left[\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + \frac{1}{r} \right]
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.5}$$

Next we recall that $u = \frac{1}{r}$ and that $\frac{l}{m} = r^2\omega$ and substitute these in

$$\begin{aligned}
GM &= \left(\frac{l}{m} \right)^2 \left[\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + u \right] \\
\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + u &= \frac{GMm^2}{l^2}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.6}$$

To simplify this equation we will use $\alpha = \frac{GMm^2}{l^2}$

6.6.2 Solution

The direct solution to

$$\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + u = \alpha \tag{6.6.7}$$

is $u = \alpha$

However because there is also a function that results in zero, we must include that

$$\begin{aligned}
\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} + u &= 0 \\
\frac{d^2u}{d\theta^2} &= -u
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.8}$$

we can take the solution that $u = c \cos \theta$ which gives the general overall solution of

$$u(\theta) = \alpha + c \cos \theta \quad (6.6.9)$$

We can pick an initial condition when $\theta = 0$ the body is at periapsis or $r = p = A(1 - e)$ which gives $u = \frac{1}{A(1-e)}$ (see the ellipse notes for $p = A(1 - e)$)

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{A(1-e)} &= \alpha + c \\ \alpha &= \frac{1}{A(1-e)} - c \end{aligned} \quad (6.6.10)$$

we could similarly have picked the condition that when $\theta = \pi$ the body is at apoapsis or $r = a = A(1 + e)$ which gives $u = \frac{1}{A(1+e)}$ (see ellipse notes for $a = A(1 + e)$)

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{1}{A(1+e)} &= \alpha - c \\ \alpha &= \frac{1}{A(1+e)} + c \end{aligned} \quad (6.6.11)$$

we can equate our two initial conditions to get c in terms of just a and p

$$\begin{aligned}
\alpha &= \frac{1}{A(1-e)} - c = \frac{1}{A(1+e)} + c \\
\frac{1}{A(1-e)} - \frac{1}{A(1+e)} &= 2c \\
\frac{A(1+e) - A(1-e)}{A^2(1+e)(1-e)} &= 2c \\
\frac{A + eA - A + eA}{A^2(1-e^2)} &= 2c \\
\frac{2eA}{A^2(1-e^2)} &= 2c \\
\frac{e}{A(1-e^2)} &= c
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.12}$$

Now that we have c we can use this to determine α in terms of A and e

$$\begin{aligned}
\alpha &= \frac{1}{A(1+e)} + c \\
&= \frac{1}{A(1+e)} + \frac{e}{A(1-e)^2} \\
&= \frac{(1-e)}{A(1+e)(1-e)} + \frac{e}{A(1-e)^2} \\
&= \frac{1-e+e}{A(1-e^2)} \\
&= \frac{1}{A(1-e^2)}
\end{aligned}$$

So feeding all this back in we have

$$\begin{aligned}
u(\theta) &= \alpha + c \cos \theta \\
&= \frac{1}{A(1 - e^2)} + \frac{e}{A(1 - e^2)} \cos \theta \\
&= \frac{1 + e \cos \theta}{A(1 - e^2)}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.13}$$

Now we have a simple form for u we can recall that we chose $u = \frac{1}{r}$, so

$$r = \frac{1 + e \cos \theta}{A(1 - e^2)} \tag{6.6.14}$$

which is the equation for an ellipse⁸.

We also get the interesting result here that

$$\begin{aligned}
\alpha &= \frac{GMm^2}{l^2} = \frac{1}{A(1 - e^2)} \\
A(1 - e^2) &= \frac{l^2}{GMm^2}
\end{aligned} \tag{6.6.15}$$

which connects the semi major axis and the eccentricity to physical properties, like the masses and the angular momentum. This will help us to work out the geometry from the physics.

⁸equation ??

Chapter 7

Elliptical Orbits

Chapter 8

Kepler's Equation

8.1 Angular rates of change

Starting with equation 4.2.8¹ that gives the relationship between the distance from the focus and the eccentric anomaly

$$r = A(1 - e \cos E)$$

We can take the derivative with respect to time to get the relationship between the rate of change of distance with time and the eccentric anomaly.

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{dr}{dt} &= A \frac{d}{dt} (1 - e \cos E) \\ &= A \frac{dE}{dt} \frac{d}{dE} (1 - e \cos E) \\ &= eA \sin E \frac{dE}{dt}\end{aligned}\tag{8.1.1}$$

Using equation 4.1.13² for the equation of an ellipse in polar form $r = \frac{A(1-e^2)}{1+e \cos \nu}$. We can invert this to get

¹page 26

²page 23

$$\frac{1}{r} = \frac{1 + e \cos \nu}{A(1 - e^2)} \quad (8.1.2)$$

which will make taking the derivative with respect to time easier.

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{1}{r} \right) &= \frac{d}{dt} \left[\frac{1 + e \cos \nu}{A(1 - e^2)} \right] \\ \frac{dr}{dt} \frac{d}{dr} \left(\frac{1}{r} \right) &= \frac{1}{A(1 - e^2)} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \frac{d}{d\nu} [1 + e \cos \nu] \\ -\frac{1}{r^2} \frac{dr}{dt} &= \frac{-e \sin \nu}{A(1 - e^2)} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \end{aligned} \quad (8.1.3)$$

we can now substitute in equation 8.1.1 for $\frac{dr}{dt}$ to get

$$-\frac{1}{r^2} e A \sin E \frac{dE}{dt} = \frac{-e \sin \nu}{A(1 - e^2)} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \quad (8.1.4)$$

We can use equation 4.1.10³ and 4.2.2⁴ for y to obtain a relationship between $\sin \nu$ and $\sin E$

$$y = r \sin \nu = A \sqrt{1 - e^2} \sin E \quad (8.1.5)$$

³page 22

⁴page 24

We can use this relationship to replace the $\sin \nu$ term in equation 8.1.4

$$\begin{aligned}
 -\frac{1}{r^2}eA \sin E \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{-e \sin \nu}{A(1-e^2)} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{-eA\sqrt{1-e^2} \sin E}{Ar(1-e^2)} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\
 &= \frac{-e \sin E}{r\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\
 \frac{-eA \sin E}{r^2} \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{-e \sin E}{r\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\
 \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{-r^2}{eA \sin E} \frac{-e \sin E}{r\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\
 \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{r}{A\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt}
 \end{aligned} \tag{8.1.6}$$

Finally we can replace r with equation 4.2.8⁵ $r = A(1 - e \cos E)$ to get

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = \frac{r}{A\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \tag{8.1.7}$$

$$= \frac{A(1 - e \cos E)}{A\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \tag{8.1.8}$$

$$= \frac{(1 - e \cos E)}{\sqrt{1-e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \tag{8.1.9}$$

Now we have an equation that links the rate of change of E to the rate of change of ν in terms of just E and ν

8.2 Using Angular Momentum

We can now use the magnitude of specific angular momentum in perifocal coordinates, given by equation ⁶ to replace $\dot{\nu}$

$$\frac{d\nu}{dt} = \frac{h}{r^2}$$

using equation 4.2.8⁷ and rearranging we obtain

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d\nu}{dt} &= \frac{h}{r^2} \\ \frac{d\nu}{dt} &= \frac{h}{A^2 (1 - e \cos E)^2} \end{aligned} \quad (8.2.1)$$

which we can now substitute in for $\frac{d\nu}{dt}$ term in equation 8.1.9⁸

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{(1 - e \cos E)}{\sqrt{1 - e^2}} \frac{d\nu}{dt} \\ &= \frac{(1 - e \cos E)}{\sqrt{1 - e^2}} \frac{h}{A^2 (1 - e \cos E)^2} \\ &= \frac{h}{A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}} \frac{1}{1 - e \cos E} \\ (1 - e \cos E) \frac{dE}{dt} &= \frac{h}{A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}} \end{aligned} \quad (8.2.2)$$

Now you can see that the right hand side is just a constant, which is defined by properties of the orbit. An interesting thing to note is that the term $A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}$ can be rewritten as the product AB instead, so linking the major and minor axes. We will however keep it in it's original form for now. Since the right hand side is a constant we will simplify by choosing the constant n for it. This constant n is the *Mean Motion*, later we will see that it's

⁶to review

⁷page 26

⁸page 59

connected to the period of the orbit, and ends up being the mean angular velocity of the orbiting body.

$$n = \frac{\frac{l}{m}}{A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}} \quad (8.2.3)$$

so finally all that is left to do is to integrate our equation with respect to time.

$$\begin{aligned} \int_{t_0}^t n dt &= \int_{t=t_0}^t (1 - e \cos E) \frac{dE}{dt} dt \\ n(t - t_0) &= \int_{E=0}^E (1 - e \cos E) dE \\ &= \int_0^E 1 dE - e \int_0^E \cos E dE \\ &= E - e \sin E \end{aligned} \quad (8.2.4)$$

$$(8.2.5)$$

Note we have chosen t_0 to be the point in time when $E = 0$, or in words the time since periapsis at epoch.

$$E - e \sin E = n(t - t_0) \quad (8.2.6)$$

If we define the *Mean Anomaly* to be $M = n(t - \tau)$, where we have given t_0 a new label $\tau = t_0$, because it is a parameter that determines something about the orbit.

We can now rewrite the equation in the more standard form of

$$E - e \sin E = M \quad (8.2.7)$$

With M being

$$M = n(t - \tau) = nt - M_0 \quad (8.2.8)$$

where M_0 is the mean anomaly at epoch, and is just another way to state τ . It is the angle the orbiting body would be at if the orbit was circular from the periapsis at time zero.

8.3 Mean Motion

We previously stated that the mean motion was related to the period without actually showing it. Here we will show the relationship. Because of the way we have integrated, we have chosen to make τ the time when the eccentric anomaly E is zero, this means that at $t = 0$ the eccentric anomaly is

$$\begin{aligned} M(t = 0) &= -n\tau \\ E_0 - e \sin E_0 &= -n\tau \end{aligned} \tag{8.3.1}$$

When the orbiting body has gone through a whole orbit, the time taken to do that will be T , or the period. The eccentric anomaly will then be $E = 2\pi + E_0$, because it has completed a full circle in terms of angle around the centre of the ellipse. So the mean anomaly is

$$\begin{aligned} M(t = T) &= nT - n\tau \\ nT - n\tau &= 2\pi + E_0 - e \sin(2\pi + E_0) \\ &= 2\pi + E_0 - e \sin(E_0) \\ &= 2\pi - n\tau \\ nT &= 2\pi \\ n &= \frac{2\pi}{T} \end{aligned} \tag{8.3.2}$$

Chapter 9

Initial Conditions

9.1 Specific Total Energy

9.2 Specific Angular Momentum

9.3 Eccentricity Vector

9.4 Direction of Perifocal Plane

9.5 Phase of the Orbit, M_0

9.6 Time Evolution of the Position

Appendix A

Useful Identities

A.1 Trigonometric

$$\sin \alpha = \frac{2 \tan \frac{\alpha}{2}}{1 + \tan^2 \frac{\alpha}{2}} \quad (\text{A.1.1})$$

$$\cos \alpha = \frac{1 - \tan^2 \frac{\alpha}{2}}{1 + \tan^2 \frac{\alpha}{2}} \quad (\text{A.1.2})$$

$$\tan \alpha = \frac{2 \tan \frac{\alpha}{2}}{1 - \tan^2 \frac{\alpha}{2}} \quad (\text{A.1.3})$$

A.2 Vectors

A.2.1 Triple Vector Product

$$\mathbf{a} \times (\mathbf{b} \times \mathbf{c}) = (\mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{c})\mathbf{b} - (\mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{b})\mathbf{c} \quad (\text{A.2.1})$$

A.2.2 Scalar Triple Product

$$\mathbf{a} \cdot (\mathbf{b} \times \mathbf{c}) = \mathbf{b} \cdot (\mathbf{c} \times \mathbf{a}) \quad (\text{A.2.2})$$

A.3 Calculus

A.3.1 Quotient Rule

$$\frac{d\frac{f(x)}{g(x)}}{dx} = \frac{\frac{df(x)}{dx}g(x) - f(x)\frac{dg(x)}{dx}}{(g(x))^2} \quad (\text{A.3.1})$$

Appendix B

Old Stuff to review

B.1 Relationship between geometry and physics

We saw in the previous chapter that the geometry and the physics were linked by equation 6.6.15.

B.1.1 Angular Momentum From Geometry

We can rearrange equation 6.6.15 to get

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{l^2}{GMm^2} &= A(1 - e^2) \\ \left(\frac{l}{m}\right)^2 &= GMA(1 - e^2)\end{aligned}\tag{B.1.1}$$

Which can be further rearranged using equations ??¹ and ??²

$$\begin{aligned}
 \left(\frac{l}{m}\right)^2 &= GM \frac{A^2(1-e^2)}{A} \\
 &= GM \frac{B^2}{A} \\
 &= GM \frac{ap}{A} \\
 &= GM \frac{2ap}{a+p}
 \end{aligned} \tag{B.1.2}$$

With some further rearrangement we can obtain the angular momentum per unit mass of the orbiting body

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{l^2}{GMm^2} &= \frac{2ap}{a+p} \\
 \left(\frac{l}{m}\right)^2 &= GM \frac{2ap}{a+p} \\
 \frac{l}{m} &= \sqrt{GM \frac{2ap}{a+p}}
 \end{aligned} \tag{B.1.3}$$

B.1.2 Total Energy From Geometry

The total energy³ is given by

$$E(r, \dot{r}) = \frac{1}{2}m\dot{r}^2 + \frac{l^2}{2mr^2} - \frac{GMm}{r}$$

making this total energy per unit mass of the orbiting body instead

$$\frac{E}{m} = \frac{1}{2}\dot{r}^2 + \frac{1}{2r^2} \left(\frac{l}{m}\right)^2 - \frac{GM}{r} \tag{B.1.4}$$

¹page ??

²page ??

³equation 6.5.6

If we choose one of the apses, say the periapsis we know that at this point $\dot{r} = 0$ so the total energy per unit mass is

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{E}{m} &= \frac{1}{2p^2} \left(\frac{l}{m} \right)^2 - \frac{GM}{p} \\
 &= \frac{1}{2p^2} \left(GM \frac{2ap}{a+p} \right) - \frac{GM}{p} \\
 &= GM \left[\frac{2ap}{2p^2(a+p)} - \frac{1}{p} \right] \\
 &= GM \left[\frac{2ap}{2p^2(a+p)} - \frac{2p(a+p)}{2p^2(a+p)} \right] \\
 &= GM \left[\frac{2ap - 2p(a+p)}{2p^2(a+p)} \right] \\
 &= GM \left[\frac{-2p^2}{2p^2(a+p)} \right] \\
 &= -GM \left[\frac{1}{a+p} \right] \\
 &= -\frac{GM}{2} \left[\frac{2}{a+p} \right] \\
 &= -\frac{GM}{2A}
 \end{aligned} \tag{B.1.5}$$

Note that energy is negative because we took zero to be when the particle is at infinity. We can rearrange equation B.1.5 to obtain the semi major axis as

$$\begin{aligned}
 \frac{E}{m} &= \tilde{E} = -\frac{GM}{2A} \\
 2A\tilde{E} &= -GM \\
 A &= -\frac{GM}{2\tilde{E}}
 \end{aligned} \tag{B.1.6}$$

Where we are using $\tilde{E} = \frac{E}{m}$ to be the energy per unit mass of the orbiting body. This can then be fed back into our relationship for

angular momentum⁴.

$$\begin{aligned}
 \tilde{l}^2 &= GMA(1 - e^2) \\
 &= -\frac{(GM)^2(1 - e^2)}{2\tilde{E}} \\
 -\frac{2\tilde{E}\tilde{l}^2}{(GM)^2} &= 1 - e^2 \\
 e^2 - \frac{2\tilde{E}\tilde{l}^2}{(GM)^2} &= 1 \\
 e^2 &= 1 + \frac{2\tilde{E}\tilde{l}^2}{(GM)^2} \\
 e &= \sqrt{1 + \frac{2\tilde{E}\tilde{l}^2}{(GM)^2}} \tag{B.1.7}
 \end{aligned}$$

Which means we can work out the semi major axis and the eccentricity based on the physics.

B.1.3 Period

An orbiting body will complete a complete orbit when it has gone through an angle $E = 2\pi$, we can then use Kepler's Equation⁵ to compute the period. For ease of calculation we will assume that $t_0 = 0$.

$$\begin{aligned}
 E - e \sin E &= kt \\
 2\pi - e \sin(2\pi) &= kT \\
 T &= \frac{2\pi}{k} \tag{B.1.8}
 \end{aligned}$$

⁴equation B.1.2

⁵equation ??

The Relationship between Mean Motion and Time Period

As we have seen from equation B.1.8, the mean motion is related to the orbital period

$$k = \frac{2\pi}{T} \quad (\text{B.1.9})$$

which is how the constant gets the name *Mean Motion* as it is the mean angular velocity of the orbiting body. In this form Kelper's Equation⁶ becomes

$$E - e \sin E = 2\pi \frac{(t - t_0)}{T} \quad (\text{B.1.10})$$

Period based on physical and geometric properties

The period can be related to other geometric and physical properties by substituting equation 8.2.3 in for k , we get

$$T = \frac{2\pi A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}}{\frac{l}{m}} \quad (\text{B.1.11})$$

We can use equation B.1.2⁷ to replace $\frac{l}{m}$.

$$\begin{aligned} T &= \frac{2\pi A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}}{\frac{l}{m}} \\ &= \frac{2\pi A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}}{\sqrt{GMA(1 - e^2)}} \\ &= \frac{2\pi A^2 \sqrt{1 - e^2}}{\sqrt{GM} \sqrt{A} \sqrt{1 - e^2}} \\ &= \frac{2\pi \sqrt{A^3}}{\sqrt{GM}} \end{aligned} \quad (\text{B.1.12})$$

⁶equation ?? on page ??

⁷page 68

We can get this in terms of the apses by using equation ?? on page ?? to substitute in for $A = \frac{a+p}{2}$.

$$\begin{aligned}
 T &= \frac{2\pi\sqrt{A^3}}{\sqrt{GM}} \\
 T^2 &= \frac{4\pi^2}{GM} A^3 \\
 &= \frac{4\pi^2}{GM} \left(\frac{a+p}{2}\right)^3
 \end{aligned} \tag{B.1.13}$$

Note that we have squared T to make the equation easier to work with, but this reproduces one of Kepler's Law, that the square of the period is proportional to the cube of the semi major axis⁸.

⁸or more usefully the average of the apses

B.2 In Plane Position and Velocity over time

We will assume that the apses are known as well as the central mass. From this the period is given by equation B.1.13 on page 72

$$T = \sqrt{\frac{4\pi^2}{GM}} \left(\frac{a+p}{2} \right)^{\frac{3}{2}}$$

At any given time we can calculate the eccentric anomaly E using Kepler's Equation⁹

$$E - e \sin E = 2\pi \frac{(t - t_0)}{T}$$

Since this is transcendental, it will need to be solved numerically, or by approximation. This text will not cover those methods, and assume that E can be determined as a function of t .

B.2.1 Position

Once E is known, then the position can be determined by

$$\begin{aligned} e &= \frac{a-p}{a+p} \\ r &= A(1 - e \cos E) \\ x &= r \cos \theta = A(\cos(E) - e) \\ y &= r \sin \theta = A\sqrt{1-e^2} \sin E \end{aligned}$$

B.2.2 Velocity

Angular Velocity

Using equation B.1.2 on page 68 to get the angular momentum

$$\left(\frac{l}{m} \right) = \sqrt{GM} \sqrt{\frac{2ap}{a+p}}$$

⁹equation B.1.10 on page 71

and using equation ?? on page ??, we can get the angular velocity as

$$\omega = \frac{l}{m} \frac{1}{r^2} = \sqrt{GM} \sqrt{\frac{2ap}{a+p}} \frac{1}{r^2} \quad (\text{B.2.1})$$

Radial velocity

The radial velocity we obtain from the geometry. Recall that we have

$$r = A(1 - e \cos E) \quad (\text{B.2.2})$$

As we did for the derivation of Kepler's Equation, we can differentiate with respect to time. Which gives the result

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = eA \sin E \frac{dE}{dt} \quad (\text{B.2.3})$$

And looking at Kepler's Equation again

$$\begin{aligned} E - e \sin E &= 2\pi \frac{t - t_0}{T} \\ t &= \frac{E - e \sin E}{2\pi} T + t_0 \\ \frac{dt}{dE} &= \frac{1 - e \cos E}{2\pi} T \end{aligned}$$

which gives us the result that

$$\frac{dE}{dt} = \frac{2\pi}{T} \frac{1}{1 - e \cos E} \quad (\text{B.2.4})$$

We can put this back in to our earlier equation to get the radial velocity

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{2\pi}{T} \frac{eA \sin E}{1 - e \cos E} \quad (\text{B.2.5})$$

or in terms of the apses

$$\frac{dr}{dt} = \frac{2\pi}{T} \frac{a - p}{2} \frac{\sin E}{1 - e \cos E} \quad (\text{B.2.6})$$